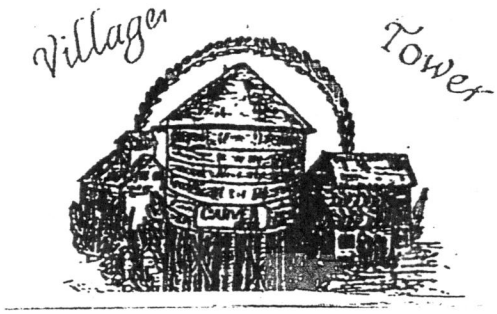
Volume XXIII
Number Two Hundred Fourteen
April/May/June 2005



What If This Was Your Child?

We raise our children with the ultimate expectations of watching them grow old, fall in love, marry, reproduce and make us happy grandparents. For most of us, that happens and we don't think twice about those children robbed of this 'dream'.

What happens to that child when this dream is shattered? What emotions transpire when their world is ripped apart with a different idea for their futures? Do we even think about it? Do we know what happens to those lost souls suffering quietly and immeasurably? Do we care? Of course we care. How could we not?

Mother's Day is right around the corner. Mothers are the ultimate portrayal of sacrifice, selflessness and unconditional love, the fixer upper, the person who makes it all right. What happens when mom can't make it right? What happens to the mom who has somehow become inflicted with a disease(s) and or illness? Branded with terminal illness? What happens to the mom who is no longer able to think beyond three, six, nine months or maybe a year? What happens to the mom whose own mother worries beyond description unable to fix her daughter's dilemma yet somehow feeling responsible? What happens now to the son she gave birth to?

What sickens, frustrates and even angers us is the bureaucratic system with all their rules and regulations refusing the financial help to this mom whom by no fault of her own has become a victim to the illness, the diseases and the system. There is neither rhyme nor reason to the insanity of the sudden roller coaster ride this mom and anyone close to her is thrown onto. The inability to have enough money to cover all those necessities involved with not only living and surviving, but also the raising of her child alone, adding yet another the daily cost incurred for expensive medicine needed daily. Where is the money to come from? Who will help? I can't work? I can't get a job because I am sick? Where am I to live? How do I pay the bills? How do I feed my child? How do I get the medicine? How do I stay warm? These are the recurrent pounding daily questions that only barely scratch the surface of the spiraling whirlwind sucking you under, adding additional stress to the medical condition, physical stress and on and on. One wonders how you keep your head above water. How to keep from sinking further down and drowning, not to mention succumbing to the overwhelming depression. And then there's the rapid regression into the sinking financial disaster. And yet, the system continues to kick them over and over and over and the continuous 'kick 'em' when they're down" syndrome.

Where's the justice?
What happens to this child?
Are they any less deserving than another child?
Everyone is someone's child?
Is this child to be left behind?
What can be done? How can someone help? Where do they turn when the system turns their back on them?
The even scarier prospect to this scenario is where you know one of these cases, the odds are that there are ten or more others jettisoned right into a similar situation. We all know what happens to these children.
We pretend we don't.

Only if you know someone or are in the same predicament can you truly appreciate the agony, anguish, despair, hopelessness, urgency and betrayal that they struggle with daily. Who can help these children?

By: Ricki Yvonne Schultz

Financial Management

The city council held a special meeting at the Fire Station/Public Works Facility with the financial advisors from Ehlers and Associates to discuss the financial management planning for the city for the next five to ten years. Presently budgeting is done annually. The financial advisor's goal was for multi-year budgeting involving modeling and including building, staffing, infrastructure needs and large project issues anticipated for the future. The pavement management plan implemented last year was discussed. The financial advisor presented an overview of the contents of the program and discussed the utilization of Tax Increment Financing. Suggestion was also submitted that the Fire Department personnel be included in these plans since presently the department demonstrates the greatest needs for this planning strategy. It was also explained to the council the importance of securing a rating involving borrowing money because this rating would denote lower interest rates when bonding.

Miscellaneous

The council was approached concerning conducting an economic study and a market study within the city. The mayor stated that it was his opinion that the city probably was not interested in becoming involved with a market study but would however be interested in the results. The individual who had approached the council with the request would proceed with a study.

Did You Know .....

... that Carver's first regularly practicing physician was Dr William A Griffin who settled in Carver in 1857. By 1882 he had practiced medicine in Carver for more than a quarter of a century, in the early years often taking food or other goods as payment for his services.

...the in August 1871 the Minneapolis and St Louis Railroad line between Carver and Glencoe began construction, with as much as a mile of track being laid weekly.

Proposed Ordinance

The city planner presented the council with a blackline version of the Bluff and Ravine Overlay District Ordinance proposal. This said ordinance would replace the existing portion of the Zoning Ordinance. The Planning Commission recommended approval with amendments. The attorney was not able to be at the meeting. His input was preferred so the council would have time to review the proposed ordinance. Motion was made and carried with all ayes to schedule a work session for the proposed ordinance.

...that the Township of Carver and Carver County were situated in what was once called "The Big Woods" of America. Though the soil was very fertile, the quantity and predominance of hardwood trees made clearing of farmland very difficult for pioneer settlers.

Future Growth

The council held a special meeting to discuss future growth in the city. The city attorney, administrator, financial advisor, and city planner met with the Metropolitan Council. The council was reminded of the adoption of the resolution starting the negotiation process for connection to the MUSA lines for sanitation waste. The attorney informed the council that the Metropolitan Council had submitted a plan to Carver County for taking possession of municipal wastewater treatment plants. The process expectations for accomplishment of this take over was explained to the council.

The attorney further explained the implications involved with this process with the Met Council. The WasteWater Treatment Plant would have to be torn down. The attorney expressed concern regarding the debt on the plant. There could be complications involved in connection fees. The Met Council would build a transfer station transporting the wastewater to the Met Council's system.

Question was asked about how much capacity the city would have on the MUSA lines. The Met Council determines the best way to serve the city. They build the interceptor and the city would be required to build the lines. There are seventeen cities in the metropolitan area with their own wastewater treatment plants, but Carver is so close that it makes sense to connect them to the MUSA. It was relayed what the Met Council's Sewer Availability Charge per residential connection and that two thirds of the construction costs are paid by the Sewer Availability Charge and the balance by user fees. The city would receive money for their plant as set by the State Statute.

The Met Council would be ready to meet with a consultant staff from the City Of Carver to discuss issues. The Met Council is presently conducting a study on the growth in the are and another plant could be required to be built. The council was told that it could still be four to five years before there is an infrastructure to accommodate the City of Carver. However, the Met Council is very interested in meeting with Carver regarding a connection to their system.

The mayor pointed out that the City's general view is that there is a lot of growth wanting to expand west. It is anticipated that by the year 2030 the City of Carver will be the size of present day City of Chaska population counts. The attorney stated that the council needs to make a decision within the next six months whether or not to connect to the MUSA Line or expand the city's municipal system because of the necessity for more capacity and the number of developers approaching the city.

The council was also told that during their meeting with the Met Council the issues of bluff and density were discussed. The city planner told the council that the density issue is one that needs to be addressed with the Met Council. Included in this issue involved the importance to consider the bluffs and soils in Carver. Ordinances need to be in place to meet requirements. The council also needs to address affordable housing. Negotiations will be necessary with developers concerning the density and open space in order to meet with the Met Council's requirements.

Lisa's Place

The council reviewed responses and input received from the community regarding the request for band music outdoors on weekends in the downtown area. Residents did not oppose occasional non-amplified music but did not support every weekend having to listen to music outdoors. Music can be heard from within the bars as is. The council made the motion to reject the request for outdoor music at Lisa's Place.

Farm Home

The Heritage Preservation Commission reviewed proposed development concept design for property for residential development with a brick home on the site. The developer's plans for the brick from the home was to utilize it for a monument or gate into the development. The commission's thoughts were more of interest to incorporate the home into their developmental plans. Moving the home had been researched and appeared to be not viable. Further research would be required on the issue.

Did You Know...

....that at Carver the Minnesota River Valley is cut deeply into Cambrian and Ordovician sedimentary rocks. The valley has a trough-like shape with walls reaching heights of 250 feet.

Municipal Utilities

The engineer reminded the council that test wells are necessary to determine the location of the water supply to supply future growth. The cost of the plans were discussed and adjustments to this plan required consideration. Staff spoke with residents concerning an agreement and right of entry to construct a test well and the staff is still in the process of contacting others for the same purpose. The engineer presented schedule proposal for the council to review. Motion was made and carried with all ayes approving the plans and specifications as well as to schedule the bid date in May. Completion of the feasibility studies was asked about. The engineer listed the studies and the approximate date of completion.

The engineer reported to the council regarding decisions in the past for MnDOT to construct casing pipes below the new highway for future municipal utilities at the northwest corner of the state highway and the county road. The engineer explained the approximate location of these pipes west of the existing intersection and that this work would be completed in conjunction with the design build project and the cost related to this issue. The engineer pointed out the cost saving savings at present rather than in the future and recommended that the city proceed with this casing work and authorize the forwarding of a letter to authorize the work by MnDOT. Motion was made and carried with all ayes approving the Design/Build/Sewer/Water casing cost.

The engineer explained the issue for the request of an extension on County Road #147 at Old Gilfillan. A sewer extension was requested as part of the previous agreement between the city and the owners of the gravel pit. The agreements related to the provision of service in exchange for land. The engineer reported that quotes received were to extend the sanitary sewer line by directional drilling under the county road. A permit from the county would be necessary. Three quotes had been received and the engineer recommended reviewal of the quotes and authorizing proceeding with negotiations with the lowest bidder. Motion was made and carried with all ayes authorizing the work to fulfill the Mueller agreement

Certified Local Government Status

The City Planner informed the Heritage Preservation Commission that the City of Carver had been accepted for Certified Local Government Status if the commission, staff and city council elected to choose this status for the city. However, doing this could inflict stricter standards on approvals of projects within the district and could present financial complications for residents meeting these conditions. There were reservations about such a status. The issue would be examined further.

Minnesota Valley Electric Cooperative

Some of us readers are on Mn Valley Electric and some are on Excel (formerly NSP). Well for those of us who are participants with MN Valley Electric they are holding their annual meeting and Member Appreciation Day at the Scott County Fair Grounds on June 22nd from 5 PM to 8:30 PM. Dinner will be served from 5:30 PM to 7 PM then the business meeting will begin. There will be pony rides, petting zoo, moon walk, face painting and many more kids activities available. All MVEC members are invited.

Carver Softball/Baseball Youth Association

Softball starts the week of May 16th. T-Ball will begin June 2nd at the East Union School. During the month of June you can watch the youngsters playing t-ball at the school on Tuesdays and Thursdays. Boys Baseball will also be starting in May – District #112. Be sure to come and see our games at the Community Park and Lions Park. These games will be in June and into July, around the 13th. The Girls Softball Tournament will be July 15th, 16th and 17th at the Chaska Pioneer Field.

Disclaimer

The 'unapproved' minutes of the council and the township have been referenced for the purposes of reporting news in the "*Villager Tower*" and creating the contents of this newsletter for the purpose of informing residents in the City of Carver and the townships surrounding the city.

Did You Know...

....that on May 26th, 1877 Carver Township was dissolved and was reorganized under law as a Carver Village.

Carver Black Sox

Submitted by Paul Reimer

Did you know that the Black Sox have a web-site? Check it out: www.carverblacksox.com

"Black Sox Schedule"

2 PM Games
May 8th - Gaylord at Carver
May 15th - Prior Lake at Caver

7:30 PM
May 17th - Carver At Norwood Young America
May 19th - Carver at Jordan

2 PM Games
May 21st - Mound at Carver
May 22nd - LeSueur at Carver
May 28th - Waconia at Carver
May 29th - Carver At Arlington

1 PM Game
June 4th - Carver at St Louis Park

2 PM Game
June 5th - St Peter at Carver

7:30 PM Game
June 9th - Carver at Victoria

1 PM Game
June 11th - Shakopee at Carver

2 PM Games
June 12th - Chaska at Carver
June 19th - Carver at Winthrop

7:30 PM Game
June 21st - Carver at Brownton

2 PM Games
June 25th - Carver at New Germany
June 26th - Belle Plaine at Carver

7:30 PM Game
June 28th - Carver at LeSueur

2 PM Game
July 9th - Carver at Waconia

Unless Old Timer Games: 12 PM and 3 PM

July 10th - Carver at Cologne

2 PM Game
July 17th - Arlington at Carver

Play offs start on the week of the 17th – and we hope to see you at the park having a good time

Tentative Agenda

City Of Carver Council Meeting
Monday Evening 6:30 PM

1) Call to Order
2) Pledge of Allegiance
3) Approve Agenda
4) Petitions, Requests and Communications
5) Consent Agenda
6) Engineer's, Planner's and Attorney's Reports
7) Administration
8) Liaison Reports
9) Other Business
10) Adjourn

Carver Lions

Reminder: if you are interested in joining others at the Twin's game with the Yankees at the MetroDome, then you should know that there are still tickets available to join fellow Lions and residents to this game.

The Lions would also like to take this time to extend a gracious thanks to everyone for making the Pork Chop Dinner a success. A belated thanks is also extended for the breakfast success as well. Without all the help and people eating these events would not be the success that they are and everyone needs to hear how much this participation is appreciated. So thank you to everyone.

The Carver Lions are also working hard on still another fun activity for everyone to participate in. The proceeds from this event will be donated for children's hearing. This event involves Carver Couples Olympics. This event has been sponsored for three years. This year is the third year of the Olympics. It is scheduled for June 11th 2005. The fun will be from 8 AM to 9 PM either rain or shine. Sign-in will be at the Village Hall in Carver to begin the day, from there will be off to play volleyball, pool, kickball, bag toss, senior citizen's softball (kittenball), and then lunch. Then we are off to 9-Hole Scramble, basketball and completing any unfinished games. Dinner and awards. The finale will be Karaoke. There is a non-refundable fee. Per person will be $60 and $120 per team. The fee is inclusive of bussing, golf and cart, lunch, dinner, supplies, water, soda and most importantly prizes. Deadline for sign-up is May 22nd, Sunday. So hurry. You miss, you lose. There are limited number of teams that can play so get that registration form filled out to ensure your participation in all these fun events. Proceeds from these Olympics will be donated towards the Lion's 5M Hearing Foundation – The New Children's Hearing Clinic at the U of M.

PS: Participation requirements are that a team must consist of one male and one female, first come, first serve basis, a full day's participation required (partial participation will not be allowed) and the minimum age is twenty-one. If you have questions, you can call Joe Knutsen at 952) 292-7836. [Registration Form below for your convenience]

The Carver Lions would also like to share their pride in being able to contribute to the following organizations: Operation Iraqi Children Fund, American Diabetes Association, Easter Egg Hunt, Lions Eye Bank, a Scholarship Fund, Boy Scout Troops #303 and #174.

The Lions are planning lots and lots of fun activities and lots of things are going on. Don't let another event take place without you. Come and join the Lions. They meet at the Village Hall on the first and third Wednesday of the month. Come and check it out. You might be surprised what impact your participation could have and how much self gratification you can experience.

Twins Game

Do you like baseball? How about the Twins? Do you like the New York Yankees? Would you like to see the Twins play the Yankees? Well, here's a deal you can't pass up. We are going to the Twins game in June at the Metrodome. Specifically on June 4th, Saturday. So if you don't like to drive in the cities and you want to go see a baseball game, we have all the answers for you.

All you have to do is to contact one of these following businesses and we'll get you all set up. You contact Carver Liquors, Hans Hagen Homes, the HazelNut House or Harvey's Bar and Grill. Tickets will be available April 15th. Transportation will be available to the metrodome. A coach bus has been reserved for this event. This is a first come, first serve basis, so don't take too long to think about it. The tickets are $35 per person. At 3:30 on June 4th, we will all meet at the Carver Fire Station for appetizers and beverages. At 4:30 PM the coach bus will be loaded and we'll be off to watch the Twins play ball with the Yankees.

Dahlgreen Golf Course

Dahlgreen Golf Course 2005 Events

All course hosted events can also be conveniently registered securely on line... website www.dahlgreen.com

May 7th	- The Spring Opener
May 30th	- The Memorial Day Sweepstakes
June18th	- The Summer Showdown
July 9th	- The Dahlgreen Classic
August 13th	- The Club Championships
August 26th	- Member/Guest
September 5th	- The Autumn Harvest
September 9th	- Dahlgreen Pro- AM Valley Automotive Group
September 10th	- Twin Cities Golf Tour
September 24th	- The Fall Showcase
October 9th - 20th	Annual Die Hard Classic
October 29th	- 5th Annual Frosty Pumpkin



3rd Annual Carver Couples Olympics 2005 Registration Form

Team Member 1 _____ Email _____

Team Member 2 _____ Email _____

* Registration is due by Sunday, May 22nd. Please make checks payable to Carver Lion's Clul

Please drop off or mail registration and payment to : Joe Knutsen
834 Ramsey Avenue
Carver, MN 55315

"Remember The Veteran"

Submitted By Ralph Hanson
On Memorial Day – Remember the Veteran

Remember When

I remember
A boy not quite a man
Saw a sign that said, "I Want You"
I enlisted, intending to see the world
I remember
Basic and Advanced Training
The DI, Marching, KP, the Rifle Range,
Spit shined boots,
Wondering why I did this
And finally Graduation as a Private
Hoping my family was as proud as I Was

I remember
Getting Orders
Writing to tell my parents
I was going to a country
I never heard of and barely able to find it on a map

I remember
Arriving by troop ship and finding my assigned unit
Hearing the sounds and sensing the smells of war
Not knowing then, on more smell I would experience

I remember
Meeting a nice guy
We had much in common and became good friends
We had the same first name
We both came from a small town
We both missed our families and girl friends
We shared our letters from home
We talked much or our hopes, dreams and fears

I remember
While on patrol, not far from camp
We came under fire
We dug in as best we could
It seemed like an eternity
I moved a short distance to better return fire
There was an explosion
I looked back, realizing something was very wrong
I went back, took him in my arms
Yelled "Medic", but knew they would be unable to help
For a moment the silence was deafening, as if time stood still
As he breathed his last, I sensed the smell of Death
I tried to dry me tears, because men aren't supposed to cry
Serge yelled, "Move Out!"
I left him, never to see him again, but today only a memory.

This same scene has been repeated over the centuries in all the battles of all the wars.
We come together each Memorial Day:

To
REMEMBER
THEM

Did You Know...

....that in February 1868 pioneer blacksmith John Bloedel (born 1834) lost his Carver blacksmith and wagon making shop to a fire. Four years earlier his property had been involved in another fire.

Carver Art Celebration

The Carver Women's Organization is sponsoring the Carver Art Celebration. This celebration is scheduled to occur on Sunday the 26th of June at 10 AM and closing at 5 PM. Funky Minds has plans for fun kids projects. There is a rumor that Chuck Tuma is going to tell railroad stories. Someone told this writer that all kids like railroad stuff? Is this true?

The downtown area will have artists displaying and selling their artwork. Box lunches, pop and water will be sold. You can bet all of those box lunches will be absolutely delicious. Lisa's will be providing entertainment on the patio by the popular "Vodka Tonic Band".

Three days prior to the event is scheduled what they define as 'plein aire painting' workshop. (Plein aire means painting the view before you outside). You will see these artists out and about somewhere in Carver. These artists will then be displaying their paintings that they have created of the beautiful settings that Carver offers.

There will also be a quick draw in the gazebo. Everyone will have the opportunity, if you want, to try their hand at drawing 'still life' that is set up before them. Instruction and helpful hints will come by way of a real artist. After thirty minutes, your masterpiece will be sprayed with a matte varnish and off you go to show off your creation to everyone. A very nice remembrance of your day in Carver! The Carver Hair Salon will be offering the kids a chance to have their hair painted or spiked. Now that sounds like much more fun than face painting, don't you think? This event is being advertised but more importantly, the women want the town's people to come and stroll through and see what's going on in the streets of Carver and to take in the art and feel like you are part of the wonderful event and town. There are more activities in the planning stages. Be sure to come. Mark those calendars right now. June 26th from 10 AM to 5 PM, downtown Carver on Sunday. It will be fun.

Villager Tower

The area is growing so fast, there are new people and new faces everywhere you turn. Anyone interested in submitting an article or news, information pertinent to the community is welcome to contact Ricki Schultz at 952) 448-5126. Businesses are welcome to introduce themselves. Our staff is small. Thanks for reading and contributing.

Carver Fire Department Highlights and Community Calendar — June 2005

June 1st - Lions Meeting
June 2nd - Drill Night
T-Ball begins
Happy Anniversary Kerry and Kathy!
June 4th - Twins Baseball Game
June 5th - Happy Birthday Kim!
June 6th - Council Meeting
June 7th - Women's Organization Meeting
June 8th - SteamBoat Days Committee Meeting
Last Day of School
June 10th - Commencement Class
"Class of 2005"
June 11th - Carver Couples Olympics
June 13th - Park and Recreation Board Meeting
Dahlgren Township Board Meeting
June 14th - Flag Day
June 15th - Lions Meeting
- Happy Anniversary Russ and Barb!
June 18th - Happy Birthday Gwen!
June 19th - Father's Day
June 20th - Council Meeting
Drill Night
June 21st - First Day of Summer
Heritage Preservation Commission Meeting
June 22nd - MN Valley Electric Member Appreciation Day
- Happy Anniversary Kim and Paul!
June 26th - Carver Art Celebration
June 27th - Comprehensive Plan Work Group Meeting
- Happy Birthday Erna!
June 28th - Planning Commission Meeting
June 30th - Fire Department Meeting
- Happy Anniversary Terry and Shirley!
- Happy Birthday Yvonna!

SteamBoat Days

The HazelNut House has gone and done it once again. She has gotten them creative instincts grooving and created yet another quilt to be raffled off at the fall 2005 SteamBoat Days. Linda has named her quilt, "Stars and Stripes – Americana Quilt". It measures 95" x 95" equating to a very large queen size quilt. The art piece will be displayed at HazelNut House the last week in May for viewing. Prior to this time, you will have to travel to Chanhassen to the 'Sampler' Shop where it is presently being displayed. Linda had other artists create some of the blocks on this quilt. The quilt will be the grand prize this year at SteamBoat Days.

I, the editor would like to add my comments and "Job Well Done Linda"! Once again, she has outdone herself. I went and personally checked out this "Stars and Stripes – Americana Quilt". The best description I can give is: "WOW!" It is very impressive. Every block is from a different perspective and clearly defines each artist's impression of the stars and stripes interpretation to them. I am not quite sure how exactly to describe it to you because it would literally take sitting beside it and analyzing each and every block and unfortunately I don't have the time to do that and right now I truly regret that. It is impressive and probably has a different meaning and reaction for every individual who drinks in the beauty and diversity. Like I said "WOW!" I am impressed to say the least. It truly is a reflection of the 'American Spirit', pride and loyalty for America. Good job to everyone contributing each and every block. Art and its uniqueness should never ever go unrecognized because there is a lot to be said for the creation of items that literally have meaning of some kind to the creator, if only we could truly understand their portrayals of their inner souls and personal feelings so deep within them that the beauty created by each and every artist is truly magnificent and awesome. Like a raw energy released. Don't wait for Linda to bring the quilt to Carver, take a drive up to Chanhassen and check it out. It's inside in the back room on the west wall. You can't miss it. As soon as you see it, you know it 's the one you seek.

That's right, this year, there will be ten other items being raffled off. They are great items. You can thank your local businesses for their donations this year. Please remember to acknowledge them and tell them thanks. The other items being raffled include a Mystic Lake Package donated by WKP, Inc, a Dahlgreen Golf Club Package donated by the golf club, a 7 ½ ' artificial Christmas tree donated by Vickerman, Inc., a digital camera donated by Swanson and Associates, a barbeque grill donated by Lisa's Place, a $75 Gift Card to the Carver Depot donated by the Depot, two $50 Gift Certificates, one donated by the Silver Bullet and the other by Harvey's and the last item donated by the Klein Bank is a $100 Savings Bond. Thank you. How do you start the process for winning these great items you ask? You can purchase raffle tickets from any Carver business. You can buy one raffle ticket for $2. or buy six tickets for $10.00.



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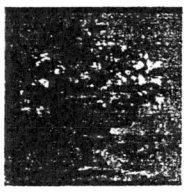
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Lisa's Place

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Sunday - Open at Noon
Grill Hours - Monday thru Saturday
10 AM - 12:30 AM

Mothers

Author Unknown

For those who are lucky to still be blessed with your Mom, this is beautiful. For those who aren't, this is even more beautiful.

The young mother set her foot on the path of life. "Is this the long way?" she asked. And the guide said "yes, and the way is hard. And you will be old before you reach the end of it. But the end will be better than the beginning."

But the young mother was happy, and she would not believe that anything could be better than these years. So she played with her children, she fed them and bathed them, and taught them how to tie their shoes and ride a bike and reminded them to feed the dog and do their homework and brush their teeth.

The sun shown on them, and the young mother cried, "Nothing will ever be lovelier than this."

Then the nights came, and the storms, and the path was sometimes dark and the children shook with fear and cold and the mother drew them close and covered them with her arms, and the children said, "Mother, we are not afraid, for you are near and no harm can come."

And the morning came, and there was a hill ahead, and the children climbed and grew weary, and the mother was weary. But at all times she said to the children, "A little patience and we are there." So the children climbed, and as they climbed they learned to weather the storms. And with this, she gave them strength to face the world.

Year after year, she showed them compassion, understanding, hope, but most of all...unconditional love.

And when they reached the top they said, "Mother, we would not have done it without you."

The days went on, and the weeks and the months and the years, and the mother grew old and she became little and bent. But her children were tall and strong, and walked with courage. And the mother, when she lay down at night, looked up at the stars and said, "This is a better day than the last, for my children have learned so much and are now passing these traits on to their children." And when the way became rough for her, they lifted her, and gave her their strength, just as she had given them hers.

One day they came to a hill, and beyond the hill, they could see a shining road and golden gates flung wide.

And mother said, "I have reached the end of my journey. And now I know the end is better than the beginning, for my children can walk with dignity and pride, with their heads high, and so can their children after them."

And the children said, "You will always walk with us, Mother, even when you have gone through the gates." And they stood and watched her as she went on alone, and the gates closed after her. And they said: "We cannot see her, but she is with us still. A Mother like ours is more than a memory. She is a living presence."

Your Mother is always with you. She's the whisper of the leaves as you walk down the street, she's the smell of certain foods you remember, flowers you pick and perfume that she wore, she's the cool hand on your brow when you're not feeling well, she's your breath in the air on a cold winter's day. She is the sound of the rain that lulls you to sleep, the colors of a rainbow, she is Christmas morning. Your Mother lives inside your laughter. And she's crystallized in your every teardrop. A mother shows every emotion.....happiness, sadness fear, jealousy, love, hate, anger, helplessness, excitement, joy, sorrow, and all the while, hoping and praying you will only know the good feelings in life.

She's the place you came from, your first home, and she's the map you follow with every step you take. She's your first love; your first friends, even your first enemy, but nothing on earth can separate you.

Not time, not space... not even death!

Pass this on to all the mothers and daughters and sons you know. May we never take our Mothers for granted.

Happy Mother's Day !

